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SIRAJ FIRES INDIA TO SERIES-LEVELLING WIN

Indian players celebrate the dismissal of Jamie Overton on day five of the fifth Test against England at The Kia Oval in London, yesterday. With England needing just 35 runs and India requiring four wickets on the final day, Mohammad Siraj struck the first blow, dismissing Jamie Smith in the second over. In his next, he removed Overton to swing the momentum India's way, before finding the perfect yorker to uproot Atkinson's off stump and help India seal the win by just 6 runs and square the series 2-2.

AP

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Arabic ranked as the fifth most spoken language in the world

English, Mandarin, Hindi and Spanish make up the top four

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

In 2025, Arabic has been ranked as the fifth most spoken language in the world, with an estimated 335 million speakers, according to data from Ethnologue, a leading authority on global language statistics.

Topping the list is English, spoken by approximately 1.5 billion people worldwide, followed by Mandarin with 1.2 billion speakers. Hindi holds third place with 609 million, and Spanish comes fourth with around 558 million speakers. Arabic, one of the six official languages of the United Nations and a cornerstone of cultural identity across the Arab world, continues to

play a vital role not only in communication but also in religion, education, and diplomacy.

Linguistic demographics

Ethnologue, which specialises in language intelligence and research, provides key insights into linguistic demographics.

Although an estimated 7,159 languages are spoken globally today, the vast majority are used by only a fraction of the population. According to recent data, 90 per cent of these languages are spoken by fewer than 100,000 people each. The 20 most spoken languages are the first language of over 3.7 billion people, nearly half the world's population, despite accounting for just 0.3 per cent of all known languages.

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UAE growth to accelerate over next two years

REAL GDP TO EXPAND BY 4.4% THIS YEAR AND RISE TO 5.4% IN 2026

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE

Your Money Editor

The Central Bank of the UAE (CBUAE) projects a stronger economic outlook for the country over the next two years, underpinned by continued momentum in the non-oil sector and resilient financial system performance.

In its newly released 2024 Financial Stability Report, the CBUAE forecasts the UAE's real GDP to expand by 4.4 per cent in 2025 and accelerate further to 5.4 per cent in 2026, following 4 per cent growth in 2024. The upward trend reflects sustained economic diversification efforts and the robust state of the country's financial and banking systems.

According to the report, the UAE's banking sector remains well-capitalised and liquid, with improved asset quality supporting ongoing expansion. Financial stability risks remained broadly unchanged, supported by sound economic fundamentals and effective risk management.

Absorbing shocks

The Central Bank's analysis of macroeconomic trends and financial market conditions highlights ongoing stability in 2024, with the financial system maintaining its capacity to ab-

4%

was UAE's growth in 2024, marking the start of upward trend

sorb shocks even under adverse scenarios. Stress tests conducted during the year confirmed that banks could continue lending while holding capital and liquidity well above regulatory thresholds.

Complementing the economic outlook, the non-bank financial institutions (NBFIs) sector – including insurance, finance companies, and exchange houses – recorded solid performance. The insurance sector posted 21.4 per cent growth in gross written premiums, reaching Dh64.8 billion, with solvency remaining adequate.

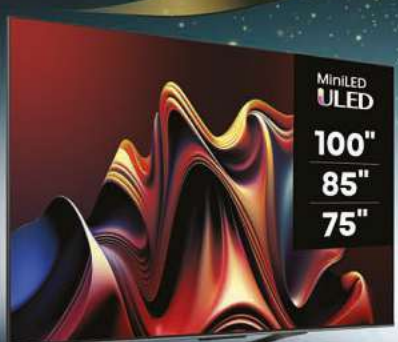
Digital transformation in financial services also accelerated in 2024. FinTech adoption, digital payments, AI integration, and data analytics progressed across the sector. The launch of the domestic card scheme "Jaywan", broader uptake of the "Aani" Instant Payment Platform, and advancements in the Digital Dirham initiative further enhanced payment infrastructure efficiency and resilience.



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